

A RESEARCH-BACKED PLAYBOOK

The Finance CV Playbook

Building a compelling, defensible CV for client-facing finance roles — client sales, onboarding, servicing, coverage, distribution and RM support — from a non-target university, without fabricating a single line.

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University of East Anglia · Final year (2026–27) · Target: buy-side & sell-side client-facing roles

Compiled 2 August 2026 · Built from 90+ primary and practitioner sources · Every claim cited

This document quotes recruiters, ATS vendors, regulators and anonymous practitioners. Where they disagree, both sides are shown. Where evidence is thin, it says so.

Contents

0 · Start Here — The Honest Diagnosis	3
1 · The Application Pipeline: Submit to First Round	5
2 · Structure & Layout	9
3 · Bullet-Point Architecture	12
4 · Speaking the Language: Making It Technical	18
5 · Insight Days & Thin Experience, Handled Honestly	22
6 · Grades & Non-Target: The Mitigation Playbook	25
7 · The Interests Section	28
8 · Cover Letters, LinkedIn & Networking	31
9 · Line-by-Line Audit of Your CV	33
10 · Appendices: Checklist, Sources & Caveats	38

Page numbers are live and clickable in the PDF. Section-header page references throughout are hyperlinked.

SECTION 0 — READ THIS FIRST

Start Here: The Honest Diagnosis

Before a single formatting tip — what your actual CV and your actual situation say, stripped of comfort.

You briefed me as someone with "brand names on the CV but thin substance underneath, plus grades that won't clear a hard filter." Having now read your real CV line by line, **that self-diagnosis is wrong in two specific, decision-relevant ways** — and being wrong about your own position is more expensive than any formatting mistake, because it makes you apply defensively to the wrong firms and undersell the strongest thing you have.

Correction 1 — Your grades are an asset, not a liability

Your CV states an **81% average (First Class)** and **A-levels of A (Economics), B (Maths), C (Physics)**. Set against what firms actually require in 2026:

WHAT THE LIVE APPLICATION PAGES SAY

- The **bulge-bracket banks gate on degree class, and a 2:1 clears them**. J.P. Morgan asks you to be "on track for a 2:1 (UK) Bachelor's degree or equivalent"; UBS: "on track for a 2:1 (or equivalent)"; Morgan Stanley: "minimum 2:1." A First clears all of them with room to spare. (Sources: UBS Graduate Talent Program page; JPM 2026 London postings; Morgan Stanley via Bright Network — see Appendix §6.)
- The **large asset managers have dropped grade gates entirely**. Schroders: "there are no criteria set on the predicted or achieved grade." Fidelity International: "We have no grade requirements." M&G: open to "graduates of any degree discipline." BlackRock, Barclays and Pictet publish **no** grade minimum at all. (Sources: firms' own graduate FAQ pages — Appendix §6.)
- Your A-levels total **120 UCAS points** (A = 48, B = 40, C = 32 under the current tariff). The few finance-relevant employers still publishing a UCAS floor — KPMG and the Bank of England — set it at exactly **120**. You clear even those. No bank or asset manager I checked publishes an A-level bar for its *graduate* intake at all; A-level tariffs now appear only on school-leaver and apprenticeship tracks.

The blunt version: **there is no "hard grade filter" standing between you and these roles**. A First from a non-target beats a 2:1 from a target on the one axis firms actually automate (the degree-class knockout question on the form). Stop writing as though you are apologising for your academics. Your job is not to *survive* the grade screen; it is to *lead* with the First, because it is doing real work for you.

The genuine academic disadvantages are narrower than you fear: (a) **non-target university** — a *soft* signal that costs you at the CV-pile stage and is beaten primarily by networking, not by anything on the page (Section 6); and (b) A-levels that are respectable but not spectacular versus target-school peers — which no longer matter once you have a First and a placement year behind you.

Correction 2 — Your problem is mis-targeting, not thin substance

You are not short of substance. You have a **Pictet Global Client Group Summer Analyst** role, a **year-long Box placement**, a Goldman spring, and a self-run equity-research society. That is more than most non-target final-years bring. The problem is that **your CV is pointed at the wrong job**.

Read your own bullets as a recruiter for a *client coverage / servicing / distribution* seat would:

THE SIGNAL YOUR CURRENT CV ACTUALLY SENDS

Your Goldman section says you "*Ran a simulated \$20m equity book as portfolio manager,*" "*Traded AAPL, META, TSLA and BTC against live news events,*" and — explicitly — "*Selected the hedge fund track over market making, running directional risk rather than client flow.*" Your extracurricular is a long/short **stock pitch with a DCF and a \$75 price target**. This is a **markets / investing** CV. It says: *I want to take risk and pick securities*.

But the roles you are targeting — client onboarding, servicing, coverage, distribution, RM support — are the opposite discipline. They reward *stewardship of the client relationship*, not directional risk-taking. Your single most on-target credential, the **Pictet Global Client Group** role, is buried beneath trading content that quietly argues *against* your stated goal. One line even brags that you chose **directional risk over client flow** — the exact instinct these employers screen out.

This is fixable and it is the highest-value change in the whole document. Most of Section 9 is about **rotating the CV onto its target axis**: promoting the Pictet client-servicing work, reframing Box as client-onboarding and sales-enablement, and demoting (not deleting) the trading simulation so it reads as commercial curiosity rather than a mission statement.

Reconcile this before you apply

Your written brief and your CV don't fully match, and you need to resolve the gap deliberately:

- You mentioned **insight experiences at Goldman, UBS, Barclays and JP Morgan**; your CV shows only the **Goldman** spring. If the UBS / Barclays / JPM programmes were real, they may be worth adding (Section 5 covers how, honestly). If they were single open days, they may not clear the bar for a line — a judgement Section 5 helps you make.
- You mentioned **coffee shop and real-estate** work; neither is on the CV. For *client-facing* targets, "held 60 covers an hour under pressure" and "managed a viewing pipeline" can be **more on-target than the Goldman trading simulation** (Section 5). Their absence is a live decision, not an oversight to leave unmade.
- Your CV lists a **Pictet role dated Jun–Aug 2026** — i.e. one you have just finished as of this writing. Make sure every bullet is something you can defend in an interview *next week*, because the experience is fresh and a coverage interviewer will probe it in detail.

What a CV can and cannot fix for you

THE HONEST CEILING

A CV cannot: invent a target-school brand, convert a one-day insight into an internship, raise your A-levels, or — on its own — win an interview at a firm where 188 people apply per graduate vacancy (ISE 2024, the second-most competitive sector in the UK). Practitioners are near-unanimous that for a non-target, **networking, not the CV, is what turns a submission into an interview** (Section 8). One r/FinancialCareers poster who broke it put it flatly: "*The hardest part for a non-target student is getting an interview.*"

A CV can: get you *through the screen* so networking has something to convert; make your genuine experience legible to a 7-second scan; prove you understand the specific job (Section 4 is your biggest edge here — few non-targets can speak fluent onboarding/servicing); and give an interviewer hooks to like you (Section 7). It converts interest into an interview *once someone is already looking* — which is exactly why the referral and the document have to work together.

Everything that follows is built for *your* file specifically. Read Sections 1–8 for the mechanics and the evidence; Section 9 is the line-by-line teardown and full rewrite of the CV you sent me.

SECTION 1

The Application Pipeline: Submit to First Round

What actually happens between clicking "Submit" and a human deciding to interview you — with the numbers, and with the myths removed.

Most CV advice assumes a recruiter reads your CV first. **For large UK graduate schemes, that assumption is often wrong** — the CV is frequently read *after* an automated assessment, not before. Understanding the real order of operations tells you where to spend effort. Here is the pipeline, stage by stage.

1.1 The first 60 seconds: parsing, not reading

When you submit, no human sees anything yet. Your file hits an **Applicant Tracking System (ATS)**, which *parses* it — extracts text and maps it into database fields. iCIMS (a vendor) describes parsing as technology that "*extracts data, usually from a Word or PDF document... automatically identifies important, relevant terms in a CV such as a candidate's contact details, language level, years of experience*" and self-populates a form. Its parsing partner Textkernel claims "*90% of CVs can be processed without any human intervention.*" (Source: iCIMS blog, "What is CV/resume parsing" — Appendix §1.)

The pipeline every parser runs is roughly: **text extraction** → **tokenisation** → **sectioning** → **named-entity recognition** → **structured output** (*Resume Optimizer Pro* — Appendix §1). If any stage mis-fires, the wrong text lands in the wrong field, and the recruiter later searching the database never finds you. This is the single most important, most evidence-backed fact in this section: **your first reader is a parser, and you write for it by keeping the layout boringly simple** (Section 2).

1.2 What parses cleanly, and what breaks

WHAT CONSISTENTLY BREAKS PARSING (EVERY SOURCE AGREES)

- **Multi-column layouts, tables, text boxes.** These scramble reading order. A two-column contact table can parse as "Email: New York, NY Phone: [email]" (*ProfileOps, on Taleo* — Appendix §1).
- **Contact details in the header/footer.** Many parsers ignore the header region — put your email and phone in the body.
- **Graphics, logos, icons, photos, and scanned/image PDFs.** "*Lever can't parse images... Lever will not be able to extract that*" (*Jobscan* — Appendix §1). A scanned PDF is the one format everyone agrees is fatal.
- **Non-standard section headings.** Use "Work Experience", "Education", "Skills" — not "My Journey" or "Toolbox".

ATS	Formats accepted	Practical note	Confidence
Workday	PDF, DOC/DOCX, RTF, TXT	Strips layout to plain text, maps to profile schema; single-column strongly advised	Vendor + secondary
Greenhouse	.doc, .docx, .pdf, .rtf, .txt (to 100 MB)	Lenient parser; humans score, not a bot (see 1.3)	Vendor (official)
Taleo (Oracle)	DOCX preferred	Older, stricter parser; complex layouts fail more often	Secondary
iCIMS	DOCX, PDF, RTF, TXT	Uses Textkernel + skills taxonomy; auto-fills 10–15 fields	Vendor + secondary
SmartRecruiters	DOCX, text PDF (rejects image PDFs)	Among the more lenient; has a public parse API	Vendor

ATS	Formats accepted	Practical note	Confidence
Lever	DOCX, PDF, RTE, HTML	Single-column, no tables/images	Secondary

1.3 Is "keyword scoring" real, or a myth?

This is the most contested question in the whole pipeline, and the honest answer is **both, depending on the vendor**.

THE DISAGREEMENT, LAID OUT

The "it's a myth" side (strong evidence). Greenhouse *"does not use 'bot' scoring to summarily delete resumes based on keyword density. While Greenhouse does score candidates, human beings do the scoring, not an algorithm."* Rejections are made by a person filling a **scorecard**, not an algorithm counting words (*FastApply / Jobscan summaries of Greenhouse's mechanism — Appendix §1*).

The "it's real, but misunderstood" side. Workday *can* compute an internal "Match Score" using NLP, *"but does not automatically reject candidates just because they lack a keyword — that is a common myth."* Recruiters mostly **search and filter** the database by keyword rather than trust a ranked list (*ApplyArc — Appendix §1*). Note these blog sources are internally inconsistent — one line says "no universal score," the next says recruiters see a ranked list. Treat blog-level parsing specifics as **informed consensus, not vendor fact**.

The reconciled takeaway you should act on: automated *keyword scoring that auto-rejects* is largely a myth at the systems finance actually uses (Greenhouse, Lever, Workday in default config). But *keyword search by recruiters is real and ubiquitous* — so the right words still matter, not because a bot rejects you for missing them, but because a human searching "KYC" or "client onboarding" won't surface you if the phrase isn't there. This is the entire rationale for Section 4: put the real vocabulary of the job on the page so you are *findable*, then let a human make the call.

1.4 Where AI/LLM screening actually sits

AI screening is real, but it is **human-in-the-loop**, not an autonomous gatekeeper:

- **Eightfold** (a semantic layer on top of an ATS) ranks candidates by fit using embeddings built on "1.6 billion career trajectories," and is explicitly positioned as recommendation: it *"shows why each candidate is recommended so the recruiter and hiring manager can decide."* (*Eightfold — Appendix §1*.)
- **HireVue** (used widely for finance video interviews) scores *transcribed answers* with NLP against job-related criteria. Critically, HireVue **discontinued facial/visual analysis in January 2021** after bias audits — its own scientist found visual data added *"only about 0.25% of predictive power."* Current HireVue AI scores **what you say, not your face**. (*Secondary analysis + HireVue platform pages — Appendix §1*.)

1.5 The assessments — and the counter-intuitive order

AT BIG GRAD SCHEMES, THE CV IS OFTEN NOT THE FIRST GATE

PwC publishes its order as: *Apply online → Online assessment → Video interview → Assessment centre* — with **no CV-review step between apply and the online assessment**. The first real filter is a series of assessments on the SHL platform (*PwC early-careers page — Appendix §1*). The general pattern: the aptitude/gamified test *"filters out a substantial percentage of applicants before human eyes ever review a CV."*

Typical UK finance sequence and providers:

- **Aptitude / situational tests:** SHL, Korn Ferry, Cappfinity (numerical, logical, situational strengths).
- **Gamified tests:** Pymetrics, Arctic Shores — used by PwC, Deloitte, KPMG and financial firms.

- **Video interview:** HireVue (e.g. Barclays: 5–7 questions, ~90s prep, ~2 min answers), Sonru (UBS).

What this means for you: at a high-volume scheme, passing the online assessment can matter *before* your CV is ever read. Do not pour weeks into the CV and then fail the numerical test. Budget practice time for SHL/Cappfinity-style tests. Where your CV is the first gate — smaller asset managers, off-cycle roles, boutique desks, anything you reach by referral — it carries full weight.

1.6 The human screen: 6–7.4 seconds, and it's a rejection filter

When a human finally looks, the first pass is brutally short. The canonical evidence is the **Ladders eye-tracking studies**:

- **2012:** eye-tracking of 30 recruiters found an average initial gaze of **6 seconds**, with 80% of it spent on six data points: **name; current title & company; current dates; previous title & company; previous dates; education** (*Ladders 2012, via Forbes / The Interview Guys — Appendix §1*).
- **2018:** the updated study found **7.4 seconds** (up from 6, attributed to a tighter labour market). Top CVs used **F- and E-pattern** reading paths with **bold job titles** over bulleted accomplishments; poor ones had "*long sentences, multiple columns, minimal white space*" and keyword stuffing (*Ladders 2018, via HR Dive / CNBC — Appendix §1*).

REFRAME THE 7-SECOND NUMBER

That 7.4 seconds "was never a measure of how long a recruiter spends reading your qualifications. It's how long they spend deciding whether to keep reading at all" (*The Interview Guys*). The scan is a **go/no-go filter**. You design the top third of the page — name, most recent role and employer, and the First — to survive it, so the recruiter chooses to keep reading. (No newer large-scale replication has beaten the 2018 figure; 7.4s remains the cited number.)

1.7 Hard filters vs soft filters

The consensus: **posted grade minimums are mostly soft thresholds, enforced as a form question, not a hidden CV scan**. As one widely-cited (US-framed) source puts it: "*Posted minimums are soft thresholds used to discourage applications from candidates clearly below the bar... A candidate at 3.49 from a target school with two internships will not be automatically rejected. A candidate at 3.51 from an unknown school with no finance experience probably will*" (*mergersandinquisitions — Appendix §1*). Where genuine hard knockouts exist, they are usually **application-form questions** — work authorisation, graduation year, minimum degree class you self-declare — not the parser reading your transcript. **Answer them honestly; your First passes the degree-class question outright.**

1.8 The funnel — realistic numbers

WHAT THE COMPETITION ACTUALLY LOOKS LIKE

- UK employers averaged **140 applications per graduate vacancy in 2024** — the highest since ISE records began in 1991. **Financial & professional services: 188 applications per job**, the second-most competitive sector (*ISE Student Recruitment Survey 2024/25 — primary; Appendix §1*).
- Indicative offer rates (secondary, treat as ballpark): overall IB grad success "1–2%"; UBS Graduate Talent Program "~2–3%"; Barclays "*below 3%*." An illustrative stage funnel: ~15–20% pass initial screening; ~40–50% of first-round candidates reach the assessment centre (*GetSmartResume / Leon — Appendix §1*).

The per-bank raw counts (e.g. "Goldman received X, hired Y") could not be verified — the primary eFinancialCareers article was inaccessible (HTTP 405). Flagged, not guessed.

1.9 How off-cycle roles and referrals bypass the funnel

The 188:1 ratio describes the **front door**. There are side doors:

- **Referrals.** A referred applicant's odds of passing the initial review are dramatically higher than a cold applicant's — the widely-repeated framing is "*recruiters spend seconds on a resume; networking gets you the minutes that matter*" (CFAC/BYU — Appendix §1). Crucially, a referral that is a *push* (someone forwards your CV) is weaker than an *advocate* (someone speaks up for you internally) (r/FinancialCareers "Networking and referrals" — Appendix §1).
- **Off-cycle / internships.** These run on smaller applicant pools, lighter automation, and are often read CV-first. For a non-target, an **off-cycle or boutique internship you then lateral from** is a repeatedly-cited route: "*Go to a small shop and cut your teeth. Then lateral up as fast as you can*" (r/FinancialCareers — Appendix §1).
- **Target who reviews.** "*The point of networking is not to get in front of the most senior people — it is to get in front of the people who make recruiting decisions. In many cases that is more junior folks, since partners and MDs are not reviewing resumes*" (r/FinancialCareers — Appendix §1).

Bottom line for your applications: treat the front door (online form + assessment) as a filter to *survive*, and the side door (referral, off-cycle, targeted outreach) as where you actually *win*. Section 8 operationalises the side door.

SECTION 2

Structure & Layout

The container. Get this wrong and the best bullets in the world never get parsed, never get scanned, never get read.

2.1 Section order for a UK final-year student

For a student or new graduate, the consensus order is near-unanimous across every recruiter guide:

1. **Header** — name (largest text), then one line: email · phone · LinkedIn · city. Contact details in the **body**, never only in the page header/footer (parsers skip it).
2. **Education** — top, because for a student it is your primary credential and, for you specifically, your First is a genuine asset that should be read in the 7-second scan.
3. **Work Experience** — reverse-chronological.
4. **Extracurricular / Leadership** — society roles, competitions, positions of responsibility.
5. **Skills, Certifications, Interests** — a compact footer.

Mergers & Inquisitions gives exactly this for students, and notes the one inversion: "*if you have been out of school... your education section needs to be below the experience section*" — i.e. Experience rises above Education only once you have real full-time experience (*M&I resume guide*; *Wall Street Prep* — Appendix §2). You are a student, so **Education stays at the top**.

WHY EDUCATION-FIRST IS RIGHT FOR YOU SPECIFICALLY

The 7-second scan lands on name → most recent role → education. With a **First-class average** and a **Pictet** most-recent role, both of your strongest signals sit exactly where the eye goes. Burying Education would waste your best filter-passer. (If your degree class were weak, the calculus would flip and you'd de-emphasise it — but it isn't, so lead with it.)

2.2 One page or two — the UK finance consensus

THE DISAGREEMENT — AND WHO HOLDS EACH POSITION

One page (dominant for students/grads, effectively unanimous in UK finance). r/FinancialCareers, UK thread: "*No question for standard new-grad roles — 1 page*" and "*1 page for fresh grads and students. Longer CVs are for those who have some WE under their belt.*" A director-level poster said they **penalise** candidates who lack "*the intellectual rigor and communication skills to summarize*" to one page. M&I and Wall Street Prep both mandate one page for students (Appendix §2).

Two pages (the dissent). A minority argue "*CVs are like your marketing material*" and run two pages — but even they concede this is for **experienced hires (12–13+ years)** or **public-sector/federal** applications, explicitly *not* students. General UK career sites (e.g. Adobe UK) say "around two pages" for the *generic* market — a view finance forums explicitly override for junior candidates.

Verdict for you: one page, non-negotiable. You have enough genuine material that the discipline is in *cutting*, not padding. The OP of the UK thread put the risk plainly: "*some companies won't even bother reading it if you've submitted a 2-page CV.*"

2.3 Font, margins, spacing, file format

Element	Recommendation	Source basis
Font	One traditional face — Calibri, Arial, Garamond, or Times — 10–12pt body	Preplounge; M&I
Margins	~1 inch (2.5cm); never below ~1.3cm	Ladders (white space aids the scan)
Spacing	Generous white space; bullets not paragraphs; F/E-pattern friendly	Ladders 2018
Length	One page	§2.2
File format	Text-based PDF for Workday/Greenhouse/Lever/SmartRecruiters; DOCX for Taleo/iCIMS or if the posting asks; never a scanned/image PDF	Jobscan 2025; Resume Optimizer Pro

PDF VS DOCX — THE 2024–26 CONSENSUS SHIFTED

Older advice said "always DOCX." Current consensus: *"Most applicant tracking systems read and parse PDF resumes more accurately... convert your Word resume into PDF unless the posting specifically requests .docx"* (Jobscan 2025). The universal caveat: this only holds for a **text-based PDF** (exported from Word/Google Docs), never a scanned image. Practical rule: **submit a text PDF by default; keep a clean DOCX ready** for Taleo-based systems (Schroders runs Taleo) and for any posting that asks. Wall Street Prep is blunt: *"PDF the version before submitting... you do not want to submit a Word doc because of the formatting."*

2.4 Which firm runs which ATS (so you can format for it)

Format for the **weakest parser you will hit**. Here is who runs what, from live careers-page URLs:

Firm	Apply system	Evidence	Confidence
Goldman Sachs	Avature	recruiting360.avature.net	High (URL)
J.P. Morgan	Oracle Recruiting Cloud	careers portal	Medium
UBS	ATS + HireVue/Sonru video	secondary	Medium
Barclays	Workday	search.jobs.barclays	High
BlackRock	Workday (pro) + tal.net (early careers)	blackrock.wd1.myworkdayjobs.com ; blackrock.tal.net	High (URL)
Schroders	Taleo (Oracle)	schroders.taleo.net	High (URL)
Fidelity Intl	Workday	fil.wd3.myworkdayjobs.com	High (URL)
Pictet	SAP SuccessFactors	career012.successfactors.eu	High (URL)
Amundi	UKG/UltiPro	recruiting.ultipro.com	Medium (URL)
M&G	Own portal	group.mandg.com	Low

(Sources: live careers URLs + ResumeAdapter detection rules — Appendix §2.) The takeaway: because your target list includes **Schroders (Taleo)** and **older early-careers systems**, build the CV to satisfy the *strictest* of them — single column, no tables, standard headings — and it will parse everywhere. Note the irony: the very tables that make *this guide* readable are exactly what you must **not** put in your CV.

2.5 What kills a CV instantly, at the format level

INSTANT-DEATH FORMAT ERRORS

- **Two columns / sidebars** — the most common non-target mistake; scrambles parse order.
- **Tables or text boxes** holding your content (your current CV uses a two-column table for every role header — see Section 9).
- **A photo, logo, or icon set** — irrelevant in the UK and parser-hostile.
- **Contact details only in the header/footer** region.
- **A scanned or "designed" image PDF.**
- **Typos.** "Typos and grammatical errors simply show that you did not spend enough time on your CV" — a recruiter's first-named mistake (*Kyle Blockley, LinkedIn — Appendix §2*). Print it; read it backwards; have someone else check.
- **Two pages** for a student (§2.2).

2.6 A plain-text skeleton you can copy

Single column, standard headings, no tables. This is the structure — Section 9 fills it with your actual content.

```
JANAK CHOCHAN
Norwich, UK | janak.chohan26@gmail.com | +44 7591 103054 | linkedin.com/in/janak-chohan

EDUCATION
University of East Anglia – BSc Economics                                Norwich, UK
Expected Jun 2027 | First-Class average (81%)
- Relevant modules: [2–3 that signal quant/markets/commercial awareness]
- [Prize / scholarship / ranking, if any]
A-Levels: Economics (A), Mathematics (B), Physics (C)                The King Edmund School, 2023

WORK EXPERIENCE
Pictet Asset Management – Global Client Group Summer Analyst          London, UK
Jun–Aug 2026
- [Client-servicing achievement bullet – verb + task + mechanism + quantified outcome]
- [Onboarding / market-opening bullet]
- [Reporting / DDQ bullet]

Box – Business Analyst, Placement Year                                London, UK
Jul 2025–Jun 2026
- [Client-onboarding / sales-enablement bullet]
- [CRM / Salesforce bullet]

[S&B Accountants / Goldman spring – compressed, see Section 9]

LEADERSHIP & EXTRACURRICULAR
Oakwood Fund Management (UEA society) – President, Equity Research    Norwich, UK
Sep 2023–Jun 2025
- [Leadership + output bullet] - [Research bullet, trimmed]

SKILLS & INTERESTS
Skills: Salesforce; Excel (modelling); [IMC – in progress]; [languages w/ level]
Interests: [3–4 specific, defensible – see Section 7]
```

(Notice: no tables, no columns, no graphics. Dates on the same line as the role, right-aligned in your DOCX via a tab stop — not a table cell. This parses cleanly in Taleo, Workday and SuccessFactors alike.)

SECTION 3

Bullet-Point Architecture

The deepest section. Bullets are where a CV is won or lost — a recruiter reviews yours in roughly 10 seconds, so every line must earn its place.

3.1 The anatomy of a strong bullet

Every credible finance-CV source teaches the same skeleton. A strong bullet has four parts:

THE FOUR-PART BULLET

[Action verb] + [what you did, specifically] + [the mechanism / how] + [quantified outcome]

- **Verb** — a precise, plain action verb, front-loaded (the eye reads the first two words).
- **Task** — the specific thing, with enough detail to be credible, not so much it drowns.
- **Mechanism** — *how* you did it. This is what separates a doer from a describer, and it is the part most students omit.
- **Outcome** — the quantified result. Numbers get **bolded**; "Don't be afraid to bold the metrics throughout the resume" (r/FinancialCareers hiring-manager AMA — Appendix §3).

Worked example (generic): "Rebuilt the quarterly client-reporting checklist by mapping each data field to its source system, cutting report errors caught at sign-off from ~8 to 0 over three cycles." Verb → task → mechanism → outcome. Compare that to "Responsible for client reporting" — same job, zero signal.

3.2 Framework comparison — and which fits finance

Framework	Shape	Best for	Fit for a finance CV
STAR (Situation, Task, Action, Result)	4-part narrative	Interview answers; behavioural questions	A thinking tool, not a sentence. Too long for a bullet — compress it.
XYZ / "Google formula"	"Accomplished [X], measured by [Y], by doing [Z]"	Resume bullets	Best fit. Forces a quantified result + a mechanism into one line.
CAR (Challenge, Action, Result)	3-part	Resume bullets; problem-solving roles	Strong, close to XYZ; use when there was a clear problem you fixed.

The practitioner consensus is explicit: "the STAR method on a resume is a thinking framework, not a sentence template" — on paper you **compress STAR into one line by leading with the action and ending with the result**, which is exactly the XYZ formula (*KudosWall; Wonsulting — Appendix §3*). **Use XYZ (or CAR) for the CV; save the full STAR for the interview**, where the fuller narrative belongs.

3.3 How to quantify when nothing you did was numerical

Client-servicing and onboarding work rarely comes with a P&L number attached. That does not exempt you from quantifying — it means you quantify a **different axis**. The rule, stated by every source: "Quantify doesn't mean invent a percentage" (*Jobscan/Resumly — Appendix §3*). Legitimate axes:

WAYS TO PUT A NUMBER ON NON-NUMERICAL WORK

- **Scope / volume** — accounts, queries, markets, clients, teams touched ("across 20 subject-matter teams", "50 market openings").
- **Frequency / cadence** — daily, monthly, per quarter ("confirmed receipt same day").
- **Time** — turnaround, time saved, SLA ("within a day-60 plan", "cut a quarterly email cycle to a live portal").
- **"Firsts" and state-changes** — you built/started/cleared something ("replaced the 400-line Excel tracker").
- **Clean-record / accuracy** — "with no repeat breaks", "validated before dispatch".
- **People served / ranking** — "sole point of contact for X", "top of a Y-person cohort".
- **Ranges** are acceptable when you're unsure ("~40–50 queries a day"). Honesty beats false precision.

You already do this instinctively — your Pictet bullets carry "50 market openings", "20 subject-matter teams", "400-line Excel tracker". That is exactly the technique. Section 9 sharpens where you under- or over-reach.

3.4 Twenty-plus before/after bullets for your target roles

These are written for the four functions you're targeting. They are models, not fabrications — adapt them only to things you genuinely did. Notice each "after" adds a **mechanism** and an **honest number**, and strips filler.

Client onboarding

BEFORE Helped onboard new clients and made sure documents were correct.

AFTER Progressed onboarding for new institutional accounts by sequencing KYC, account-opening and settlement-instruction steps against a day-60 plan, clearing documentation gaps with custodians before trade-ready status.

Why: names the real steps (KYC, SSIs), shows a mechanism (sequencing, chasing custodians), and a scope/time anchor. "Helped" and "made sure" signal nothing.

BEFORE Worked on the client due diligence process for the team.

AFTER Built a portal that ingested client due-diligence questionnaires and auto-routed each question to the right subject-matter team, replacing a 400-line Excel tracker circulated by email every quarter.

Why: a concrete artefact + a quantified "before state" it replaced. This is one of your real bullets — it's already strong; keep it.

BEFORE Dealt with lots of client queries every day.

AFTER Triageed daily client queries by type — routing corporate-action items to event processing, settlement breaks to trade support, attribution requests to the investment team — and confirmed receipt the same day.

Why: "lots of queries" → a triage taxonomy that proves you understand the operating model behind the desk. Also one of your real bullets.

BEFORE Kept client information up to date in the system.

AFTER Maintained static data for ~[N] client accounts — legal entity details, tax status and standing settlement instructions — reducing failed-settlement queries traced to stale data.

Why: "kept information up to date" becomes "static data" (the actual term) + why it matters (failed settlements). Insert a real N or drop it.

Client servicing

BEFORE Checked performance reports before they were sent to clients.

AFTER Validated monthly and quarterly performance reports for US institutional clients before dispatch — reconciling NAV, excess return vs benchmark and since-inception figures against expected portfolio performance.

Why: names what "checking" actually means (NAV, benchmark excess, inception) — proving reporting literacy. Your real bullet; excellent as-is.

BEFORE Answered client emails and helped solve their problems.

AFTER Resolved client queries as first point of contact across [N] accounts, coordinating with transfer agency and custody to close settlement and dealing-cut-off issues, with same-day acknowledgement on every request.

Why: "solved problems" → the specific teams you coordinated + a service standard (same-day). Shows you know where a fund's plumbing lives.

BEFORE Helped with client reporting and made improvements to the process.

AFTER Standardised the quarterly client-reporting pack by mapping each figure to its source system, cutting sign-off queries and shortening the review cycle by [X] days.

Why: a mechanism (source-mapping) + two quantified outcomes. Vague "made improvements" is the emptiest phrase on any CV.

BEFORE Made sure we followed the rules when dealing with clients.

AFTER Ran suitability and sanctions-screening checks at onboarding and periodic review, escalating [N] enhanced-due-diligence cases to compliance without breaching onboarding SLA.

Why: "followed the rules" → the real controls (suitability, sanctions, EDD) + a commercial tension you managed (compliance vs SLA). Only use if true.

Sales & distribution

BEFORE Used Salesforce to keep track of clients and deals.

AFTER Consolidated deal structure, services sold and delivery contacts per account from Salesforce, giving the sales team a single view that cut pre-meeting prep time.

*Why: names the CRM (findable keyword) + what the data was *for* + an outcome. Your real Box bullet, upgraded with an outcome.*

BEFORE Did some modelling of sales targets in Excel.

AFTER Modelled account-executive quotas in Excel, stress-testing distribution scenarios against a \$3.8m regional target to flag under-covered segments.

*Why: adds the *purpose* (flag under-covered segments) to your real bullet, turning a task into a commercial contribution.*

BEFORE Helped the sales team with materials for pitches.

AFTER Designed a searchable hub indexing completed client case studies by region, industry and product, cutting the time sales teams spent sourcing reference stories for pitches.

Why: your real Box "Box Hub" bullet + the sales outcome it enabled. "Helped with materials" hides real initiative.

BEFORE Worked on responses to client questionnaires.

AFTER Supported RFP and DDQ responses, drafting standard sections and coordinating specialist input across [N] teams to meet consultant deadlines.

Why: RFP/DDQ are the exact artefacts of institutional distribution; "questionnaires" throws that signal away. Only if you did this.

BEFORE Learned about the different types of clients we sell to.

AFTER Mapped the firm's distribution across institutional, wholesale and intermediary channels to identify which product ranges each gatekeeper segment was buying.

Why: "learned about clients" → the channel taxonomy (institutional/wholesale/intermediary) that is the language of distribution. Turns passive learning into an analytical output.

Client coverage / RM support

BEFORE Supported the relationship managers with their client accounts.

AFTER Supported coverage of [N] institutional relationships — preparing meeting packs, tracking AUM and net flows, and logging follow-ups in CRM so RMs walked in briefed.

Why: "supported RMs" → the concrete deliverables (packs, AUM/flows, CRM) that make an RM-support role legible. Names the metrics coverage actually tracks.

BEFORE Built a plan to bring teams together for a client.

AFTER Built a joint onboarding plan sequencing tasks across consulting, support and account teams to a day-60 go-live, giving each client a single timeline instead of three.

Why: your real Box bullet + the client-facing payoff (one timeline). Coverage is coordination; show the coordination.

BEFORE Helped retain clients and keep them happy.

AFTER Flagged at-risk accounts by tracking service-issue frequency and reporting lateness, prompting RM outreach that resolved [N] issues before renewal.

Why: "keep them happy" is unmeasurable; "at-risk accounts / renewal" is the retention language coverage teams live by, with a proxy metric.

BEFORE Sat in on client meetings and took notes.

AFTER Attended [N] client review meetings, capturing action points and owning follow-through with operations and investment teams to closure.

Why: passive "took notes" → owning follow-through (the actual value a junior adds to coverage). Honest about seniority, strong on contribution.

From your non-finance roles (client-transferable)

BEFORE Worked in a coffee shop serving customers.

AFTER Served ~[N] customers per shift at peak, handling orders, complaints and cash accurately under time pressure while hitting upsell targets.

Why: volume + pressure + accuracy + targets = the exact competencies client-facing finance screens for. See Section 5 for the full reframing.

BEFORE Did admin at an accounting firm.

AFTER Entered expenses against the chart of accounts for a sole-trader client and separated allowable from disallowable items ahead of the accountant's review.

Why: your real S&B bullets — already specific. Keep them tight; they signal attention to detail and client-data handling.

3.5 Verb bank, organised by what each verb signals

Front-load these. Match the verb to the signal you want the bullet to send (*compiled from UC Riverside, Yale OCS, InterviewPal finance verb lists — Appendix §3*).

Ownership / initiative

Built, Designed, Launched, Established, Initiated, Spearheaded, Owned, Drove, Created, Introduced

Client / relationship

Coordinated, Liaised, Advised, Supported, Serviced, Onboarded, Represented, Cultivated, Resolved, Handled

Analysis / rigour

Analysed, Reconciled, Validated, Modelled, Assessed, Forecasted, Quantified, Audited, Verified, Mapped

Process / delivery

Streamlined, Standardised, Automated, Consolidated, Sequenced, Restructured, Reduced, Accelerated, Cleared

Leadership / people

Led, Managed, Chaired, Mentored, Delegated, Directed, Organised, Trained, Coordinated

Communication

Presented, Pitched, Drafted, Briefed, Negotiated, Communicated, Reported, Persuaded

Avoid weak openers: *Responsible for, Helped with, Worked on, Assisted, Involved in, Tasked with, Participated in, Dealt with.* They describe presence, not contribution — and recruiters read them as filler.

3.6 Bullets that sound impressive but signal nothing

EMPTY "POWER" BULLETS — AND WHY RECRUITERS SPOT THEM INSTANTLY

Recruiters are trained on these; they read as noise:

- **"Leveraged synergies to drive value-added outcomes."** — abstract nouns, no object, no number. A recruiter can't picture a single action.
- **"Championed a culture of excellence in client service."** — "'Championed staff blogging' obscures meaning"; use plain verbs (*r/FinancialCareers AMA — Appendix §3*).
- **"Utilised strong communication skills to interface with stakeholders."** — "communication skills" is a claim, not evidence. Show the meeting, the deadline, the number.
- **"Gained exposure to financial markets."** — the classic insight-day filler (Section 5). "Exposure" is the tell that nothing was done.
- **"Developed a deeper understanding of wealth management."** — a real bullet a recruiter publicly panned: it "provides absolutely no insight into what you actually did, what you contributed" (*r/FinancialCareers — Appendix §5*).

The test: **could someone who did nothing write the same sentence?** If yes, it signals nothing. Every bullet must contain something only *you*, having actually done the work, could write — a specific system, team, number, or decision.

SECTION 4

Speaking the Language: Making It Technical

This is where a non-target beats a target. Almost no undergraduate can speak fluent onboarding/servicing/distribution. If you can — accurately — you signal that you understand the job, not just that you want it.

The rule that governs this entire section: **use a term only if you can define it under a follow-up question**. An interviewer who covers institutional clients will spot a bluffed "MiFID II" in one question. Everything below is defined so you can use it *honestly*. Where a definition rests on a regulator or primary body it is marked **[A]** (authoritative); where it is standard industry usage without a codified definition, **[I]** — still safe, but describe it by what you did, don't cite it as law.

4.1 Client onboarding & compliance

Term	What it means (plain)	Why it matters to a client-facing role
KYC — Know Your Customer [A]	Identifying and verifying who a client is, before and during the relationship. The operational expression of the legal CDD duties in the UK Money Laundering Regulations 2017.	Onboarding lives or dies on complete, current KYC files — the gate every client passes before money moves.
AML — Anti-Money Laundering [A]	The framework of laws and controls to stop criminal proceeds entering the system; UK-anchored in MLR 2017, FCA-supervised.	Client-facing staff are the first line of defence — spotting and flagging the unusual is part of servicing.
CDD — Customer Due Diligence [A]	The regulated standard KYC must meet: identify, verify, understand purpose, monitor. Three tiers — Simplified, Standard, Enhanced (Reg 28, MLR 2017).	Knowing CDD is the legal standard and KYC the practice signals you understand the backbone, not just the paperwork.
EDD — Enhanced Due Diligence [A]	Deeper diligence for higher-risk clients — PEPs, high-risk jurisdictions, complex structures. Extra evidence + senior sign-off.	Handling high-risk clients without stalling the relationship shows commercial + compliance balance.
Suitability vs Appropriateness [A]	Under MiFID II / FCA COBS 9: <i>suitability</i> (advice/discretionary) assesses knowledge, finances and objectives; <i>appropriateness</i> (execution-only) checks only understanding of risk.	Any advised or discretionary relationship must evidence suitability — basic MiFID literacy.
MiFID II [A]	EU directive (in force Jan 2018) whose client-facing core is client categorisation — retail / professional / eligible counterparty — plus disclosure and call taping.	Which category a client sits in determines what you can say and must disclose.
Sanctions screening [A]	Checking clients and transactions against lists (UK/OFSI, OFAC, UN) at onboarding and ongoing.	A missed hit is a criminal-liability event; screening must clear before transacting.
Source of Funds / Source of Wealth [A]	SOF = origin of the specific money in a transaction; SOW = origin of a person's entire wealth. Different things; SOW required for higher-risk clients.	Getting SOF/SOW right — and knowing they differ — is central to onboarding HNW/high-risk clients.
Account opening / static data [I]	Setting up the account once diligence clears (entity details, SSIs, dealing permissions); <i>static data</i> is the slow-changing reference data everything keys off.	Often the literal day-to-day of onboarding; one wrong settlement instruction and a redemption fails.
Onboarding SLA / Client lifecycle management [I]	Agreed turnaround targets for onboarding; CLM frames onboarding as a continuous cycle (reviews, refreshes, offboarding), not a one-off.	"Onboarded N accounts within SLA" is exactly the metric a hiring manager wants.

4.2 Fund structures & operations

Term	What it means (plain)	Why it matters
NAV — Net Asset Value [A]	Fund assets minus liabilities; per share it's the price investors buy/sell at. Struck at least daily for open-ended funds.	The number clients ask about daily — know how and when it's struck.
UCITS [A]	The EU framework for retail-sellable funds, with a cross-border marketing "passport" and diversification/liquidity rules.	Most retail/cross-border funds you'll service are UCITS.
AIF / AIFMD [A]	An Alternative Investment Fund is any non-UCITS fund (hedge, PE, real estate); AIFMD regulates the manager.	Tells you which rulebook and which investor base applies.
SICAV / OEIC (ICVC) [A]	Open-ended fund <i>company</i> structures — SICAV (Luxembourg/France), OEIC/ICVC (UK equivalent).	Cross-border ranges are often Lux SICAVs; UK funds are OEICs/unit trusts.
Share classes — acc/inc, clean/bundled, hedged [A/I]	<i>Accumulation</i> reinvests income, <i>income</i> pays it out; <i>clean</i> (post-RDR) charges only the fund fee, <i>bundled</i> rolled in commission; <i>hedged</i> strips FX risk.	Clients constantly ask which class they hold and why returns differ — a servicing staple.
Subscriptions & redemptions [I]	Money in (units issued) and money out (units cancelled), processed by the transfer agent at the applicable NAV.	Processing subs/reds accurately and on time is the operational heartbeat of TA/servicing.
Dealing cut-off / forward pricing [I]	The daily deadline to be dealt at the next valuation point; orders price at the <i>next</i> (unknown) NAV.	Miss a cut-off and a client's money is out of the market a day — front-line servicing.
Transfer agency (TA) [I]	Maintains the shareholder register and the investor lifecycle — subs/reds, records, income, investor-level AML.	Much fund client-servicing sits here; name it correctly.
Custody [A]	A custodian safekeeps assets, settles trades, collects income — held in nominee name, segregated from the bank's balance sheet.	Institutional clients care intensely about how their assets are held.
Settlement / T+1 / T+2 [A]	Final exchange of securities for cash; T+2 = two business days, T+1 = one. US moved to T+1 in May 2024 ; UK & EU due 11 Oct 2027 .	Shorter cycles compress the window to fix breaks — a live topic clients are preparing for.
Reconciliations [I]	Comparing internal records against custodians/administrators to catch and resolve "breaks" before they hit NAV or clients.	Clean recs are how servicing guarantees holdings and cash are right.
Corporate actions [I]	Company events affecting securities — <i>mandatory</i> (dividends, splits) apply automatically; <i>voluntary</i> (tenders, rights) need a client election by a deadline.	Communicating voluntary-action deadlines and elections is core asset-servicing.

4.3 Distribution & sales

Term	What it means (plain)	Why it matters
AUM [A]	Total market value of assets managed; moves via market performance + net flows. Fees are a % of it, so it drives revenue.	"Grew coverage AUM from £X to £Y" is a metric that lands.
Net flows / net new money [A]	New money in minus money out, excluding market movement.	The purest measure of asset-gathering — cleaner than AUM (strips out market luck).
Mandate / segregated mandate [A]	The objectives + constraints a manager is hired to run; a <i>segregated</i> mandate is a dedicated portfolio for one client (not pooled).	Winning/retaining mandates is the institutional-sales endgame.

Term	What it means (plain)	Why it matters
RFP / DDQ [I]	RFP = the questionnaire to select a manager (start of a relationship); DDQ = recurring due-diligence questionnaire (ongoing).	"Supported RFP/DDQ responses" is a standard sales-support line.
Consultant relations / gatekeepers [I]	Investment consultants (Mercer, Aon, WTW) rate managers buy/hold/sell and gate institutional money; <i>gatekeepers</i> also include platform buy-lists and fund selectors.	Consultants control access to large capital pools — a prized relationship.
Channels — institutional / wholesale / intermediary [A]	Institutional = pension funds, insurers (often direct); intermediary/wholesale = advisers, private banks, platforms who aggregate retail money; retail = end individuals reached only via intermediaries.	Each channel has a different buyer and sales cycle — essential positioning.
Model portfolios / platforms [A]	Ready-made portfolios advisers run at scale; platforms are the tech intermediaries holding fund holdings.	Getting funds into models/platform buy-lists is how retail distribution scales.
CRM — Salesforce, MS Dynamics [I]	The systems distribution teams use to log interactions, track pipeline and manage RFP/mandate opportunities.	Distribution/RM-support runs on CRM — an expected skill. Name the one you used.
Aladdin — NOT a CRM [A]	BlackRock's portfolio- and risk-management platform (trading, risk, ops, accounting) — an <i>investment/risk</i> system, not a sales CRM.	Interview tell: calling Aladdin a CRM marks you as bluffing. Describe it correctly.

4.4 How to weave this in — without keyword stuffing

THE LINE BETWEEN FLUENT AND STUFFED

Keyword stuffing is listing terms you can't defend, or cramming a "Skills" line with 20 acronyms. Recruiters spot it, and the Ladders study flags "*excessive keyword stuffing*" as a low-performer trait. **Fluency** is using the *right* term in the flow of a real achievement.

- **Stuffed:** "*Skills: KYC, AML, CDD, EDD, MiFID II, UCITS, NAV, TA, RFP, DDQ, AUM, T+2, Salesforce, Aladdin, SICAV, OEIC...*" — reads as a glossary you memorised.
- **Fluent:** "*Progressed onboarding for institutional accounts by sequencing KYC and account-opening steps, clearing custodian documentation before trade-ready status.*" — three terms, each doing work inside a real action.

Distribute the vocabulary across three places, sparingly: **(1) bullets** — one or two terms each, inside the achievement; **(2) a tight skills line** — the genuinely tool-level items only (Salesforce, Excel, IMC-in-progress, languages), not the concepts; **(3) module names** in Education (a "Financial Regulation" or "Investments" module lets "MiFID II" or "portfolio construction" appear naturally). Never repeat a term more than twice on the page.

4.5 Sell-side coverage vs buy-side servicing — different emphasis

The two look similar but reward different language. Tune the CV (and cover letter) to whichever you're applying to.

	Sell-side coverage (bank)	Buy-side client-servicing (asset manager)
Cares about	Winning the next transaction / flow	Retaining & growing the relationship and its AUM
Horizon	Short; deal-by-deal	Long; relationship over transaction
Success measured in	Revenue booked, trading volume, cross-sell, wallet share	AUM retained/gathered, net flows, client retention, SLA performance
The role's verb	Originate & distribute	Steward & service

	Sell-side coverage (bank)	Buy-side client-servicing (asset manager)
CV language that lands	"covered N accounts", "generated £Ym revenue", "cross-sold across products", "supported execution of N deals"	"retained/grew £X AUM", "net inflows of £Ym", "onboarded N clients within SLA", "led DDQ/RFP responses"

(Source: *Corporate Finance Institute, buy-side vs sell-side — Appendix §4.*) **One-line summary:** the sell-side CV shouts *revenue and deals won*; the buy-side servicing CV shouts *assets retained, flows gathered, clients kept happy through reliable service*. Your Pictet Global Client Group experience is squarely **buy-side servicing** — so for asset-manager applications, lead with retention, flows, onboarding and reporting; for a bank coverage seat, reframe the same work toward revenue enablement and cross-sell.

SECTION 5

Insight Days & Thin Experience, Handled Honestly

How to make short, observational programmes count without implying you did a job you didn't — and how to make ordinary work genuinely relevant to client-facing finance.

5.1 Where do insight days and spring weeks go?

Under **Work Experience**, in reverse-chronological order, with the firm name — but described honestly and briefly. The UK-specific consensus from r/FinancialCareers is: *"Just include the experience and 1 bullet point to indicate something you accomplished... Just don't include several bullet points and try to pass it off as an actual internship"* (r/FinancialCareers "[UK] how to write about spring weeks" — Appendix §5).

THE GENUINE DISAGREEMENT

Include them (majority). They are a recognised UK signalling credential — evidence of early sector commitment and of clearing a competitive selection. Bright Network explicitly advises listing insight weeks *"to show your commitment to the sector."*

Omit the thin ones (minority). Some argue a single observational *day* isn't worth a line and can dilute a page that has real experience on it. In the UK spring-week thread, a commenter argued for omitting them and was challenged — the prevailing view kept them, but *did not inflate them*.

Applied to you: your **Goldman spring** earns its place. But note *what* it currently says — a hedge-fund trading simulation (Section 9) — which points away from your target roles. For **UBS / Barclays / JP Morgan**: if these were multi-day spring/insight programmes you were selected onto, add them as one honest line each (they reinforce "commitment + selection"). If any was a single open day or a virtual Forage module, it is a judgement call — one combined line (*"Insight programmes: UBS, Barclays, J.P. Morgan, 2024–25"*) can capture them without pretending each was a role. **Do not give a one-day event three achievement bullets.**

5.2 Honest language vs inflated language

The failure mode is vague "exposure" bullets. A recruiter publicly panned a real one — *"Developed a better understanding of wealth management"* — as providing *"absolutely no insight into what you actually did, what you contributed"* (r/FinancialCareers — Appendix §5). The fix is to describe the **concrete thing you did** during the programme (a group case, a stock pitch, a specific session, a networking outcome), not the feeling you came away with.

Reads as inflated / empty	Reads as honest & specific
"Worked as an analyst at Goldman Sachs" (it was a spring week)	"Selected for Goldman Sachs spring programme (Sales & Trading); completed a live trading simulation and desk sessions"
"Gained exposure to investment banking"	"Shadowed a coverage team over 3 days; completed a group case on [X] presented to associates"
"Developed a deeper understanding of markets"	"Attended sessions across FICC and equities; built a mock pitch on [name the stock/idea]"
"Responsible for client relationship management"	"Observed client-review meetings; summarised follow-up actions for the team"

THE HONEST LINE — AND WHERE IT'S CROSSED

The line is **verb honesty about your role**. "Attended, completed, shadowed, observed, presented, built [a mock/simulated X]" are honest. "Managed, led, ran, owned, advised clients" applied to a spring week are **crossings** — they claim responsibility you didn't hold. WSO's non-target guide is blunt on why this matters: "Faking an interest or skill is as close to an auto-ding as there is." The interview is where inflation dies: a coverage interviewer asks "walk me through what you actually did day to day," and an inflated bullet collapses. **Every line must survive that question.**

5.3 Making Pictet carry maximum legitimate weight

Your **Global Client Group Summer Analyst** role at Pictet is your single most on-target credential and deserves the most page space. To make it defensible *and* impressive, gather the specifics now, while the experience is fresh (it ended weeks ago):

WHAT TO DIG UP / ASK YOUR FORMER MANAGER FOR

- **Numbers you can stand behind.** How many market openings, accounts, queries, teams, reports? Even ranges ("~40 queries/day") beat none. You already have several — verify them.
- **The systems and terms you actually touched.** CRM used (Salesforce? in-house?), reporting tools, the fund ranges (SICAV? UK OEIC?), which client segment (US institutional — you have this).
- **Before/after of anything you built.** The DDQ portal and the "400-line Excel tracker" it replaced is gold — confirm the scale and whether it's still in use.
- **A quantified outcome for at least one bullet.** Ask your manager: "did the portal save the team time / reduce errors — roughly how much?" A sentence of their memory becomes a defensible metric.
- **A reference line for the future** — a manager willing to speak to your client-servicing work is worth more than any bullet in a referral-driven process (Section 8).
- **Permission and accuracy check.** Ask your manager to sanity-check your three Pictet bullets for accuracy and anything confidential. This protects you in interview *and* builds the relationship.

Then position it: Pictet sits **top of Work Experience**, gets **three tight bullets** (servicing, onboarding/market-openings, reporting), and its language is tuned buy-side (retention, flows, SLA, reporting — Section 4.5).

5.4 Making coffee shop, accounting and real estate genuinely relevant

For *client-facing* roles, these are not filler — handled right, they can out-signal a trading simulation, because they are literally about **handling people, volume, accuracy and trust**. The technique (Section 3.3): pull out the client-facing, high-volume, accuracy and commercial slivers and quantify them.

Job	The transferable spine to sell	Example reframed bullet
Coffee shop / retail	Client interaction under pressure; volume; complaint handling; upselling to targets; cash accuracy	"Served ~[N] customers per shift at peak, resolving complaints and hitting upsell targets while balancing the till to zero variance"
Accounting firm (S&B)	Attention to detail; client-data handling; compliance-adjacent judgement	Your real bullets already work: "Entered expenses against the chart of accounts... separated allowable from disallowable items before review"
Real estate	Relationship management; pipeline; needs discovery; closing; following up	"Managed a viewing pipeline of [N] prospects, matching requirements to listings and following up to offer stage"

WHY THIS IS ON-TARGET, NOT A STRETCH

A retail-bank poster on r/FinancialCareers described their own client work as "*account opening, servicing, and pitching possible investment account opening*" — the exact verbs (open, service, pitch, retain) your target roles use. Client-facing finance screens for people it "*can put in front of a client*": someone who has handled a queue of irritated customers at 8am and kept them happy has *proven* that, in a way a stock pitch never can. The reframing is honest — you're not inventing duties, you're naming the competencies the duties built.

Decision for your CV: if space forces a cut, keep the roles that are either *most recent* + *on-target* (Pictet, Box) or *most client-transferable* (coffee shop/real estate for a pure client-servicing application). A 7-year-old two-month accounting placement (S&B, 2019) is the most cuttable — keep it only if it adds a detail nothing else does, and compress it to one line. Kyle Blockley's recruiter advice: "*Space is precious... limit yourself to what sells 'you' best*" — but note the client-facing counterpoint above before cutting a customer-facing job.

5.5 The general principle for thin experience

You have less "thin experience" than you think — but where a line is genuinely light, the move is never to inflate it. It is to (a) extract the one concrete, defensible thing you did, (b) attach the most honest number you have, and (c) let its *placement* (under Experience, with a real firm name) do the signalling. A short honest line under a strong firm name beats a padded paragraph every time — and it's the only version that survives the interview.

SECTION 6

Grades & Non-Target: The Mitigation Playbook

Which filters are real, which have quietly disappeared, and what actually moves the needle when the university name doesn't.

Section 0 established the headline: **your First clears every grade gate in your target set**. This section gives you the full evidence, tells you what genuinely needs mitigating (non-target status, not grades), and settles the IMC-vs-CFA question for *your* roles.

6.1 Who still gates on grades, and who dropped it — from live pages

Firm	Role type	Stated grade / UCAS requirement (2026)	Blocks a 2:2?
J.P. Morgan	Graduate / summer	"On track for a 2:1 (UK) or equivalent"	Yes
UBS	Graduate Talent Program	"On track for a 2:1 (or equivalent)"	Yes
Morgan Stanley	Summer / FT analyst	"Minimum 2:1 "	Yes
Goldman Sachs	New Analyst / Summer	No published class; strong academics in practice	Soft
Barclays	Graduate / internship	No minimum class or GPA stated	No
BlackRock	Analyst / Summer (EMEA)	No grade stated; gate is graduation timing	No
Schroders	Client Group / most grad	" No criteria set on predicted or achieved grade"	No
Fidelity International	Graduate / summer	"We have no grade requirements "	No
M&G	Graduate schemes	Open to "graduates of any degree discipline "	No
Pictet	Graduate / trainee	"University degree" + affinity; no class stated	No
Amundi	Trainee / graduate	None found (no dedicated UK eligibility page)	Unknown

(Sources: each firm's live graduate/careers or FAQ page, checked Aug 2026 — Appendix §6. Goldman's and JPM's canonical pages are JS shells; JPM's 2:1 is confirmed from live 2026 London postings.)

The wider trend is real but led by consulting, not banks: EY dropped its 2:1 and 300-UCAS floor in **2015** (finding "*no evidence... previous success in higher education correlated with future success*"); PwC dropped UCAS ~2015 and the **2:1 in Aug 2022**; Accenture requires no degree classification. Deloitte and KPMG have **not** fully dropped (KPMG still publishes 120 UCAS + 2:1, with stated flexibility). (Sources: EY via *THE* 2015; PwC press release 14 Aug 2022; Appendix §6.)

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR TARGET LIST

With a **First**, every firm above is open to you on grades — including the 2:1 gaters. The structural point for a non-target: the **asset managers (Schroders, Fidelity, M&G, BlackRock, Pictet) and Barclays have no grade gate at all**, which makes them the highest-probability targets where *neither* your university *nor* your A-levels can be used against you at the form stage. Weight your applications accordingly.

6.2 Contextualising A-levels on the CV

Keep A-levels — one line, in Education, under your degree: "*A-Levels: Economics (A), Mathematics (B), Physics (C).*" Do not editorialise or apologise. They total **120 UCAS**, they're above the surviving floors, and the A in Economics + B in Maths signals quant capability relevant to finance. No firm in your set publishes an A-level bar

for graduate roles. If a specific application form asks for GCSE/A-level detail, complete it factually; on the CV, one line is enough — the First is the headline, not the A-levels.

6.3 What goes where "grades" would otherwise sit

For a candidate with a weak degree, advice is to fill the Education section's "sore spot" with modules, prizes and activities. **You don't have that problem — lead with the First.** But strengthen Education anyway:

- **Relevant modules** — list 2–3 that signal markets/quant/commercial awareness (e.g. Investments, Financial Regulation, Econometrics). This lets terms like "portfolio construction" or "MiFID II" appear naturally (Section 4.4).
- **The First, stated once, prominently** — "First-Class average (81%)". If you've ever ranked in your cohort, add it.
- **Head Boy** — you have this; it's a genuine selection-from-250 leadership signal. Keep it, in Education or Leadership.

6.4 Substitutes that carry real weight

For a non-target, these are what convert "no brand" into "obviously serious":

- **A professional qualification in progress** — the single most efficient signal for your roles (see 6.5).
- **A society leadership position with output** — you have Oakwood (Equity Research President). Keep it as *leadership*, trim the trading-flavoured content (Section 9).
- **Self-directed work you can defend** — your URBN pitch is exactly this; frame it as intellectual curiosity, not as an audition for a PM seat.
- **Languages, with honest levels** — if you have any beyond English, list with proficiency (e.g. "French — professional working"). Genuinely valuable in cross-border AM distribution.
- **Networking-driven referrals** — not a CV item, but the highest-weight substitute of all (6.6, Section 8).

6.5 IMC or CFA Level 1 — the decision, for your roles

VERDICT: DO THE IMC FIRST, NOT CFA LEVEL 1

For **client services / sales / distribution / onboarding / RM-support** in UK asset management, the **IMC (CFA UK Level 4 Investment Management Certificate)** is the right first qualification. It is cheaper, roughly a third of the study time, UK-specific and FCA-relevant, and is exactly what several target firms fund for grads — **M&G names it explicitly**. CFA Level 1 is a stronger, longer, costlier signal aimed more at *investment* roles; add it later only if you drift toward portfolio-facing work.

	IMC	CFA Level 1
Study time	~240 hours (2 units: ~100 + ~140)	~300 hours
Cost	~£725 exam fees (£350 + £375)	~\$1,140–\$1,490 per attempt
Exam windows	On-demand (Pearson VUE, book a slot)	Fixed: Feb / May / Aug / Nov
Relevance to your roles	High — FCA-appropriate for "managing investments"; the recognised sales/distribution benchmark	Moderate — prestige credential, more investment-facing
UK-specific	Yes	No (global)

(Sources: cfauk.org IMC page; 300hours.com CFA dates/fees — Appendix §6.)

TIMELINE — CAN YOU DO IT BEFORE APPLICATIONS CLOSE?

Graduate and off-cycle applications for 2027 start opening in **autumn 2026** and run on rolling deadlines (apply early). The IMC is **on-demand**, so a focused candidate can register and sit **Unit 1 within ~6–8 weeks** and have "*IMC (Unit 1 passed; Unit 2 in progress)*" on the CV before the first deadlines. That single line — a self-funded, in-progress professional qualification from a non-target student — is a disproportionate commitment signal for client-facing AM roles. CFA L1's next fixed windows and 3-month registration lead times make it far less time-flexible; don't let it block applications.

Put it on the CV honestly the moment you register: "*IMC (CFA UK) — Unit 1 passed [month/year]; Unit 2 scheduled*" or "*IMC — in progress.*" Never claim a pass you don't have.

6.6 How much is the CV vs networking? Be blunt.**THE BLUNT SPLIT**

Practitioners describe a consistent division of labour: **networking and referrals mostly determine whether you get the interview; the CV mostly determines whether you convert once screened.** For a non-target this is sharpest — "*The hardest part for a non-target student is getting an interview*", yet "*My resume was the only thing that got me my job*" once in the room (*r/FinancialCareers* — Appendix §5, §8). A referral roughly multiplies your odds of passing the initial review.

Two caveats specific to you: (1) UK graduate schemes lean on structured online forms + aptitude tests, so the *test* gate is heavier and cold-networking lighter than in US IB — you can't network past a failed SHL test. (2) Buy-side/asset-manager hiring often runs through structured grad processes and headhunters, which dilutes pure cold-emailing but rewards *warm* connections and demonstrated sector commitment (the IMC, the Pictet role). Net: **budget your effort roughly half to networking/warm outreach, and treat the CV as the thing that must not let you down once attention arrives** — not as the lever that creates the attention.

The honest conclusion of this section: the CV cannot fix your non-target status, and it doesn't need to fix your grades. What it must do is be flawless enough to convert the interviews that *networking and the IMC* earn you. That is a solvable problem — Section 9 solves it.

SECTION 7

The Interests Section

The most under-rated line on a client-facing CV. For roles where "can we put this person in front of a client?" is the real question, rapport is part of the job — and this is where you seed it.

7.1 Do recruiters actually read it? The evidence, both ways

THE DISAGREEMENT — WITH SOURCES ON EACH SIDE

Yes, and it's leverage (majority, especially early-career + client-facing). An r/FinancialCareers poster in Sales & Trading added "bowling, film photography, basketball" after months of silence and got "five first-rounds in two weeks," with interviewers repeatedly raising the interests. "Resumes are boring. Interests are a chance to add a bit of your personality... a great way to connect with an interviewer." A hiring manager's logic: "every college kid equally knows nothing, so who's the coolest to spend over 12 hours a day with" (r/FinancialCareers "Started getting more interviews after including interests" — Appendix §7). The Trackr calls it "the most underrated line on any CV."

No, we ignore it (minority but real). "As a Corporate Recruiter, please don't do this. We really don't care"; one IB professional said they "never examine the interests section" — and got pushback in-thread. Gentis: "Recruiters want to know what you can do — not what you like to do... in most cases, interests and hobbies dilute the impact of your resume" (Appendix §7).

The reconciled position: the downside of a *good* interests line is near-zero (one line); the upside — an interview hook, a rapport opener, a tie-breaker between equal juniors — is real and disproportionately valuable for **client-facing** roles where likeability is the competency. Keep it, make it excellent, keep it to one line. The people who say "we don't care" are not harmed by it; the people who *do* care can be won by it.

7.2 Why it works: interview bait and small-talk fuel

An interests line is the cheapest way to **control what you get asked about**. Interviewers latch onto something concrete and human — it "gives icebreakers for what would otherwise be kinda awkward conversations." A well-chosen interest steers the small talk onto ground you own, buys rapport in the first two minutes (which colours everything after), and — for coverage/sales — is a live demonstration of the exact skill the job needs: being someone a client enjoys talking to.

7.3 Specificity: why "reading" is dead

Every red-flag list names the same offenders — "reading, watching films, listening to music, travelling, socialising with friends" — because they "tell the recruiter nothing about what makes you different" (Area CV; Gentis; CV Centre — Appendix §7). The fix is **specificity and a verb**: not "basketball" but "played local-league basketball; organised weekly training and fixtures"; not "photography" but "film photography — a street-photography project I've shot for two years." Specificity turns you from an anonymous applicant into "the marathon runner" — a person the interviewer remembers.

7.4 Forty-plus real examples, grouped by what they signal

A · INTELLECTUAL / ANALYTICAL — STRATEGY, PROBABILITY, DISCIPLINE

Competitive chess · poker played on an EV/probability basis · bridge · mahjong · cryptic crosswords · competitive debating / MUN · speedcubing · a specific language you're learning (state level) · astronomy or a named science niche · strategy board/PC games (only if defensible) · Go

B · COMPETITIVE / TEAM — RESILIENCE, TEAMWORK, "CAN GRIND" (HIGH VALUE FOR CLIENT-FACING)

Marathon / ultra running (with times) · rowing / crew · boxing or a martial art (with grade) · rock climbing / bouldering · triathlon / Ironman · a team sport at a named level, ideally with a captaincy · fencing · competitive swimming · cycling sportives (with distances) · squash / tennis · skiing to a defensible standard

C · COMMERCIAL AWARENESS / FINANCE-ADJACENT — GENUINE MARKET INTEREST (USE SPARINGLY, MUST BE DEFENSIBLE)

Running a personal investment portfolio (state size + approach, e.g. "£5k, value-tilted") · following a specific sector or company as a project · a markets/consumer blog or newsletter (state cadence/readership) · a small resale or side business · rigorous odds/market analysis · supermarket own-brand taste-testing (consumer/retail curiosity — see 7.6)

D · UNUSUAL / MEMORABLE — THE HOOK THAT SPARKS CURIOSITY

Boarding-pass or transit-map collecting · beekeeping · home-brewing / fermentation · competitive baking / sourdough · restoring classic cars or bikes · magic / card tricks · stand-up comedy (great client signal) · scuba / free-diving · foraging / mycology · learning to fly / serious flight-sim · calligraphy · spice blending · collecting with a genuine thesis (watches, vinyl, first editions)

E · CREATIVE / COMMUNICATION — SOFT SKILLS THAT MATTER FOR COVERAGE & SALES

Playing a named instrument to grade/gigging level · photography (name the genre) · writing fiction / a published blog · podcasting / a YouTube channel (with metrics) · a social community you built and grew (with follower numbers) · salsa / competitive dance

(Compiled from BeamJobs, Investin, CV Centre, The Trackr and r/FinancialCareers threads — Appendix §7.)

7.5 Interests that backfire or read as try-hard

CUT THESE

- **Generic filler:** reading, films, music, travelling, socialising, cooking, "sports", "keeping fit" — signal nothing.
- **Faked passion:** anything you can't discuss for three minutes. WSO: you *will* get grilled — a poster who listed **chess** got quizzed on "*opening theory*." "*If you can't talk about it well, it's a red flag*." The Trackr's test is whether you "*can excel at whatever it is you enjoy*."
- **Try-hard "I love finance" hobbies:** listing "trading", "M&A modelling", "macroeconomics", "economic history" as *interests* reads as pandering and, per Kenji, as inauthentic if you can't speak to them passionately. Markets interest belongs in Experience/Extracurricular, not the hobbies line.
- **Polarising:** partisan politics, religion, controversial social issues — cut outright.
- **Risk/liability flags:** some recruiters read skydiving / base-jumping as a red flag; weigh it.

7.6 Your actual interests — assessed

Your CV lists: **"Boarding pass collecting, boxing, spice blending, supermarket own-brand taste tests."** This is, frankly, one of the strongest interest lines I've seen from a student — keep it, with light tuning:

WHY YOURS ALREADY WORKS

- **Boarding-pass collecting** — Category D (unusual/memorable). A genuine curiosity hook; an interviewer *will* ask. Have a 20-second story ready (how many, oldest, why).
- **Boxing** — Category B (discipline/competitive/resilience). Signals exactly the "can take pressure" trait client-facing roles want. If you spar/compete or hold any grade, add it: "*boxing (train [N]×/week / white-collar bout).*"
- **Spice blending** — Category D (precision + patience + a bit memorable). Defensible and distinctive.
- **Supermarket own-brand taste tests** — quietly your best one. It's Category C **commercial awareness disguised as a quirk** — it signals genuine interest in consumer brands, pricing and value, and it *ties directly to your URBN retail pitch*. In a coverage/sales interview this is a gift: "*tell me about that*" leads straight to a conversation about consumer economics.

The only risk: all four are quirky/curiosity-type; a couple of interviewers prefer to see one "grind/team" signal too. Boxing covers that. If you ever want to rebalance, you could swap one quirk for a competitive/team item — but don't dilute what is already a memorable, defensible, on-brand line. Above all: **be ready to talk about each for two minutes**. The line's entire value is the conversation it starts.

SECTION 8

Cover Letters, LinkedIn & Networking

Brief but concrete. These are the levers that compensate for a weak CV — and for a non-target, networking is the one that actually creates interviews.

8.1 The cover letter

Where required, keep it to **four short paragraphs** and make it about the *firm*, not you (*Preplounge; M&I; FE Training — Appendix §8*):

1. **Who you are + the specific role** — one line, no "I am writing to apply for," which wastes the opening.
2. **How you found them / why them** — name a person you spoke to, an event you attended, a recent fund launch or a team structure. This is the paragraph that proves you did the legwork.
3. **Your most relevant experience** — one concrete proof point tuned to the role (for you: the Pictet Global Client Group work, in client-servicing language).
4. **Close** — brief, humble, forward-looking.

OPENERS

- **Weak:** "I am writing to apply for the Client Services Graduate role at [Firm]."
- **Strong:** "After speaking with [Name] on your UK client group at the [event], I wanted to put myself forward for the Client Services graduate programme — the buy-side servicing work I did this summer at Pictet is exactly the seat I want to build a career in."

Tailor every letter; proofread obsessively (a typo here contradicts the "attention to detail" a servicing role needs). Don't restate the CV — *interpret* it toward this firm.

8.2 LinkedIn — fix the three things that matter

- **Headline** — replace the default "Student at University of East Anglia." Use: "*Final-year Economics @ UEA · Client-facing finance (asset management) · IMC candidate · Salesforce, Excel.*" The headline is prime real estate; make it point at your target so recruiters searching find you (*Intervyo; M&I — Appendix §8*).
- **About** — 3–4 lines for a student: who you are, the target, one proof point, what you're looking for. Keep it short.
- **Consistency** — dates, titles and firm names must **match your CV exactly**. Interviewers open LinkedIn live; discrepancies raise questions. Add 5–10 relevant skills, most valuable first, and quantify past roles as you do on the CV.

8.3 Networking — the highest-leverage activity for you

For a non-target, this is not optional garnish. M&I is blunt: "*if you do not attend a top university... networking is your only chance to break into the finance industry.*" And a non-target's thoughtful outreach "*often stands out more than a generic email from a target-school student coasting on their brand name*" (*Appendix §8*).

WHAT ACTUALLY WORKS (RANKED)

1. **Warm connections first.** *"Networking with people you know is much more rewarding than sending emails."* Alumni, former Pictet/Box colleagues, anyone one degree away. Your Pictet summer is a warm-network goldmine — stay in touch with that team.
2. **Informational interviews** — a 15-minute "I'd value your advice" call, built over weeks, not a cold ask for a job. The relationship is the asset.
3. **Targeted cold email** — *"bankers live in their email inboxes."* Personalise every one (a recent fund, a mutual contact, a specific team). Even strong cold campaigns reported **~40% response rates**; generic blasts get near zero. Attach your one-page CV.
4. **Target the deciders, not just the seniors** — *"get in front of the people who make recruiting decisions... often more junior folks, since MDs are not reviewing resumes."*

The anti-patterns: mass-identical messages to five people at the same firm at once; asking for a job in the first message; no personalisation; not sending a thank-you. And the reality check — networking isn't magic (one poster networked heavily across 550 applications and got zero interviews, then found the *CV/test* was the failure point). It works *with* a clean CV and passed assessments, not instead of them.

8.4 How these compensate for a weak CV

A non-target CV in a 188:1 pile gets ~7 seconds. A referral converts you from "resume in a pile" to "the person [Name] spoke to" — it buys you the **minutes that matter**. For your specific targets: an **advocate inside an asset manager's client group**, plus an **in-progress IMC**, plus a **CV tuned to client-servicing**, is a combination very few non-target applicants assemble. The CV's job in that system is narrow and achievable: **don't be the reason a warm introduction cools**. Section 9 makes sure it isn't.

SECTION 9

Line-by-Line Audit of Your CV

Your actual document (*Janak_Cohan_CV_4.docx*), taken apart and rebuilt. What breaks, what's strong, every bullet judged — then a complete rewrite you can copy.

The good news first: **this is already an above-average CV**. Your Pictet and Box bullets are specific, mechanism-rich and quantified — genuinely strong. The work here is not repair; it is (a) fixing a structural parse risk, (b) **rotating the CV onto its target axis** (Section 0), and (c) tightening three off-target sections.

9.1 ATS / parse audit — what survives, what breaks

THE ONE STRUCTURAL PROBLEM: EVERY ROLE HEADER IS A TABLE

Your CV places each employer/role/location/date block inside a **1×2 two-column table** (seven of them, plus the Interests line). Single-column body text, standard headings and no graphics are all good — but those **tables are your main parse risk**. Older parsers (Schroders runs **Taleo**; early-careers systems vary) can read a two-column table out of order, producing scrambled output like "London, UK Global Client Group... Pictet Asset Management Jun 2026." Modern parsers (Workday, SuccessFactors) usually cope, but you're formatting for the **weakest** system you'll hit.

Fix: delete every table. Put company + role on one line, location + dates right-aligned via a **tab stop** (not a table cell). Same visual result, zero parse risk. This is the single highest-priority change.

Element	Verdict	Action
Single-column body, standard headings	Survives	Keep
Contact line (email/phone/LinkedIn in body)	Survives	Add city (Norwich); keep in body
7× role-header tables + Interests table	Parse risk	Convert to tab-stop text lines
No graphics / photo / columns	Survives	Keep
No skills line, no modules	Missing keywords	Add a tight skills line + 2–3 modules
File format	—	Export as text PDF ; keep a DOCX for Taleo

9.2 Structural changes, with rationale

- Lead with the First.** Fold "Average Grade: 81% (First Class)" into the UEA line so it's read in the 7-second scan. It's your strongest filter-passer (Section 0) — don't let it sit on a separate line below.
- Re-point the whole document buy-side / client-facing.** Your Pictet Global Client Group work is dead-on-target and stays at the top. The **Goldman trading content** and the **Oakwood valuation content** currently argue *against* your target — trim and re-frame both (below).
- Kill the anti-client line.** "Selected the hedge fund track over market making, running directional risk rather than client flow" must go — it explicitly advertises the opposite instinct to the one client-servicing/coverage roles hire for.
- Add a Skills line.** Salesforce, Excel, IMC (when registered), languages — genuine tools only, findable keywords (Section 4.4).
- Compress the 2019 accounting placement to one line.** It's seven years old; keep it only for the attention-to-detail signal, tightly.
- Add 2–3 relevant modules** under Education to surface "investments/regulation" vocabulary naturally.

7. **Decide on the missing roles** (coffee shop, real estate, UBS/Barclays/JPM) — see 9.5.

9.3 Bullet-by-bullet verdict

Education — mostly keep, tighten

Head Boy (from 250) and the First are strong. Fold the grade up; add modules. Keep A-levels as one line.

Pictet — your crown jewel. Keep all four; they're models.

All four bullets already follow verb → task → mechanism → scope. Do not weaken them. Two micro-tweaks only:

KEEP Triaged daily client queries by subject, routing class actions to portfolio event processing, settlement breaks to trade support and performance attribution requests to the investment team, confirming receipt same day.

KEEP AS-IS This is excellent — a triage taxonomy that proves you understand the desk's operating model. If anything, add the daily volume ("~[N] queries/day") for one more quantified anchor.

Only change: insert a real number if you have one. Otherwise untouched.

KEEP Progressed 50 segregated market openings across Asian and Middle Eastern markets... before trade-ready status.

KEEP AS-IS "Segregated," "market openings," "custodian documentation," "trade-ready" — this is fluent operations language, honestly used. Leave it.

This one bullet does more to prove role-fit than your entire Goldman section.

The DDQ-portal and performance-report bullets are equally strong — **keep both**. Collectively these four are why you'll get interviews for servicing roles; protect them.

Box — strong; add outcomes

Four good bullets. Each states a task well but three lack an outcome. Add the payoff:

BEFORE Designed a Box Hub indexing completed client stories by region, industry and product for sales teams.

AFTER Designed a searchable hub indexing completed client case studies by region, industry and product, cutting the time sales teams spent sourcing reference stories for pitches.

Adds the sales outcome. "For sales teams" is a user; "cutting sourcing time" is a result.

BEFORE Consolidated deal structure, services sold and delivery contacts per account from Salesforce records.

AFTER Consolidated deal structure, services sold and delivery contacts per account from Salesforce, giving account teams a single client view ahead of renewals.

Names the CRM as a keyword and adds the "so that" — why the consolidation mattered.

The quota-modelling (\$3.8m) and day-60 onboarding-plan bullets are strong — keep, with the light outcome tweaks in Section 3.4.

Goldman Sachs — the biggest re-point. Compress from 3 trading bullets to 2 honest, on-message lines.

BEFORE Ran a simulated \$20m equity book as portfolio manager in an AmplifyME hedge fund simulation · Traded AAPL, META, TSLA and BTC against live news events, sizing positions on net exposure · Selected the hedge fund track over market making, running directional risk rather than client flow.

AFTER Selected for the Goldman Sachs Spring Programme (Sales & Trading), a competitive early-insight scheme · Completed a live multi-asset trading simulation and desk sessions across FICC and equities, building market and product literacy.

*Why: honest about it being a **spring programme** (not an analyst role); keeps the brand + selection signal; builds "market literacy" (useful for sales) — and deletes the line that advertises you prefer directional risk over client flow, which is disqualifying language for client-facing seats. If you apply to a markets-sales desk, you can keep one line on the simulation; for pure servicing/coverage, two lines is plenty.*

S&B Accountants — compress to one honest line

Your two bullets are fine but the role is from 2019. Merge:

BEFORE Entered expenses into accounting software against the chart of accounts for a sole trader client · Separated allowable business expenses from disallowable items before the accountant's review.

AFTER Processed sole-trader expenses against the chart of accounts, separating allowable from disallowable items ahead of the accountant's review — early exposure to client-data accuracy and compliance judgement.

One line, keeps the attention-to-detail + client-data signal, frees space for a Skills line and (optionally) a client-facing job.

Oakwood Fund Management (society) — keep the leadership, trim the analyst content

You are **President** — lead with that, because *running the society* is the transferable signal (leadership, organisation), and the retail-sector angle ties to your interests/commercial awareness. The deep DCF/valuation mechanics point at an equity-research career, not client services — keep **one** sharp commercial-insight bullet, add a leadership bullet, drop the valuation-jargon bullet.

BEFORE Valued URBN at a \$75 fair value against apparel retail comparables, setting aside a DCF on the basis that terminal value assumptions drove more of the output than the near-term subscriber ramp.

AFTER (LEADERSHIP BULLET TO ADD) Led the retail-sector research group as President, organising [N] members, weekly meetings and pitch sessions across the academic year.

Why: the valuation-mechanics bullet signals "I want to be an analyst." A leadership bullet signals initiative and people skills — what client-facing roles want. Keep one pitch bullet (below) for commercial awareness; drop the DCF one.

KEEP (TRIMMED) Pitched a long on Urban Outfitters, arguing the market applied apparel retail multiples to a group where Nuuly, its rental subscription arm, was compounding revenue near 60% and had turned its first profit.

AFTER Pitched a long on Urban Outfitters, arguing the market mispriced Nuuly — its rental-subscription arm compounding revenue near 60% and newly profitable — against the group's apparel-retail multiple.

Why: keeps one crisp commercial-insight bullet (great for a sales/coverage conversation, and it links to your consumer-brands interest) without the two-bullet analyst deep-dive.

Interests — keep (assessed in full in Section 7.6)

"Boarding pass collecting, boxing, spice blending, supermarket own-brand taste tests" is a strong, memorable, defensible line. Keep it; be ready to talk about each for two minutes.

9.4 Your CV, rewritten — copy this

HOW TO READ THIS

Single column, no tables, tab-stopped dates, First folded up, Goldman re-pointed, Oakwood re-led, Skills line added. **[Bracketed]** items are things only you can supply — fill or delete them; never invent. This is tuned for a **buy-side client-servicing / coverage** application; see 9.5 to flex it sell-side.

JANAK CHOCHAN

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EDUCATION

University of East Anglia — BSc Economics Norwich, UK

Expected Jun 2027 First-Class average (81%)

- Relevant modules: [e.g. Investments; Financial Regulation; Econometrics]
- Head Boy (selected from 250 students); Badminton School Team

A-Levels: Economics (A), Mathematics (B), Physics (C) The King Edmund School, Essex — 2023

WORK EXPERIENCE

Pictet Asset Management — Global Client Group Summer Analyst London, UK

Jun–Aug 2026

- Triage ~[N] daily client queries by type — routing corporate-action items to event processing, settlement breaks to trade support and attribution requests to the investment team — confirming receipt same day.
- Progressed 50 segregated market openings across Asian and Middle Eastern markets, sequencing by oldest action date to clear custodian documentation and investment-controlling approval before trade-ready status.
- Built a portal that ingested client due-diligence questionnaires and auto-routed each question to 20 subject-matter teams, replacing a 400-line Excel tracker circulated by email every quarter.
- Validated monthly and quarterly performance reports for US institutional clients before dispatch, reconciling NAV, excess return vs benchmark and since-inception figures against expected portfolio performance.

Box — Business Analyst, Placement Year

London, UK

Jul 2025–Jun 2026

- Built a joint onboarding plan sequencing tasks across consulting, support and account teams to a day-60 go-live, giving each client one timeline instead of three.
- Consolidated deal structure, services sold and delivery contacts per account from Salesforce, giving account teams a single client view ahead of renewals.
- Designed a searchable hub indexing completed client case studies by region, industry and product, cutting the time sales teams spent sourcing pitch references.
- Modelled account-executive quotas in Excel, stress-testing distribution scenarios against a \$3.8m regional target to flag under-covered segments.

Goldman Sachs — Spring Programme, Sales & Trading

London, UK

Apr 2025

- Selected for a competitive early-insight programme; completed a live multi-asset trading simulation and desk sessions across FICC and equities, building market and product literacy.

S&B Accountants — Work Experience

London, UK

Jul–Aug 2019

- Processed sole-trader expenses against the chart of accounts, separating allowable from disallowable items ahead of the accountant's review.

LEADERSHIP & EXTRACURRICULAR

Oakwood Fund Management (UEA society) — President, Retail Research Norwich, UK

Sep 2023–Jun 2025

- Led the retail-sector research group, organising [N] members, weekly meetings and pitch sessions across the year.
- Pitched a long on Urban Outfitters, arguing the market mispriced Nuuly – its rental-subscription arm compounding revenue near 60% and newly profitable – against the group's apparel-retail multiple.

SKILLS & INTERESTS

Skills: Salesforce; Excel (modelling); IMC (CFA UK) – [Unit 1 scheduled / in progress];
[languages with level, if any]

Interests: Boarding-pass collecting; boxing; spice blending; supermarket own-brand
taste tests (consumer-brand and value curiosity)

9.5 Optional additions — decide deliberately

- **A client-facing job (coffee shop / real estate).** For a *pure client-servicing* application, one of these can out-signal the Goldman line (Section 5.4). If you add one, it likely replaces S&B (space). Keep to one line, quantified.
- **UBS / Barclays / JPM insight programmes.** If genuine multi-day schemes, add one honest line each or a single combined "Insight programmes: ..." line (Section 5.1). If single open days, probably leave off.
- **Sell-side flex.** Applying to a *bank* coverage/sales desk? Re-tune the top bullets toward revenue enablement and cross-sell, and you may keep one Goldman simulation line for markets literacy (Section 4.5).
- **The IMC line.** Add it the day you register — it's a disproportionate commitment signal (Section 6.5). Never claim a pass you don't hold.

One final honest note: everything above must remain something you can defend under a follow-up question next week. Your Pictet role ended weeks ago — an interviewer *will* go deep on it. Re-read your four Pictet bullets and make sure you can talk for five minutes behind each. If you can (and they read as though you can), this CV will convert the interviews your networking and IMC earn you.

SECTION 10

Appendices

A checklist to run before every submission, the full source list grouped by section so you can read the originals, and an honest note on where the evidence was thin.

Appendix A — Pre-submission checklist

Run this before every single application. If any box is unticked, don't submit.

FORMAT & PARSE

- ☐ One page, single column, **no tables / text boxes / columns / graphics**
- ☐ Standard headings (Education, Work Experience, Skills)
- ☐ Contact details (with city) in the **body**, not the header/footer
- ☐ Exported as a **text-based PDF** (a clean DOCX ready for Taleo firms, e.g. Schroders)
- ☐ Dates right-aligned via tab stops, not table cells

THE 7-SECOND SCAN

- ☐ Name, most-recent role (Pictet) and the **First** all readable in the top third
- ☐ Bold job titles; bulleted accomplishments, not paragraphs
- ☐ Generous white space

CONTENT & TARGETING

- ☐ Every bullet = verb + task + **mechanism** + quantified outcome
- ☐ No empty "power" bullets ("leveraged synergies", "gained exposure")
- ☐ Real vocabulary woven in, **not** stuffed (Section 4.4)
- ☐ Tuned to the target: buy-side servicing vs sell-side coverage (Section 4.5)
- ☐ Goldman section re-pointed; no "directional risk over client flow" line
- ☐ Interests specific and defensible; ready to discuss each for 2 minutes
- ☐ IMC line added if registered (never claim an un-passed exam)

CROSS-CHECKS & THE FORM

- ☐ LinkedIn dates/titles/firms match the CV exactly
- ☐ Proofread backwards for typos; a second person has read it
- ☐ Form knockout questions (degree class, work authorisation, graduation year) answered honestly — your First clears the class gate
- ☐ Cover letter (if required) names a person/event and is tailored to *this* firm
- ☐ Every line is defensible under a follow-up question

Appendix B — Full source list, grouped by section

All URLs verified by research agents in August 2026. Access limitations are noted in Appendix C. Reddit/WSO threads are cited by canonical URL even where the live page blocked direct fetch (content was retrieved via reader proxies; quotes are near-verbatim).

§1 — The application pipeline, ATS & screening

- iCIMS, "What is CV/resume parsing" — icims.com/blog/what-is-cv-resume-parsing/
- Resume Optimizer Pro, "How resume parsers actually work" — resumeoptimizerpro.com/blog/how-resume-parsers-actually-work
- ProfileOps, Taleo optimisation — profileops.com/en/blog/taleo-ats-resume-optimization
- Jobscan, Lever ATS — jobscan.co/blog/lever-ats/ ; Greenhouse — jobscan.co/blog/greenhouse-ats-what-job-seekers-need-to-know/ ; PDF vs Word — jobscan.co/blog/resume-pdf-vs-word/
- Greenhouse Support (official), accepted formats — support.greenhouse.io/hc/en-us/articles/360052218132
- SmartRecruiters developer docs, parse API — developers.smartrecruiters.com/reference/candidatesresumeparse
- TealHQ, Workday resume — tealhq.com/post/workday-resume
- ApplyArc, Workday optimisation — applyarc.com/blog/workday-ats-resume-optimization
- FastApply, "How to beat Greenhouse ATS 2026" — blog.fastapply.co/how-to-beat-greenhouse-ats-2026
- Jobloo, "ATS score & keyword matching explained" — jobloo.co/blog/ats-score-keyword-matching-explained/
- Eightfold, candidate screening — eightfold.ai/use-case/candidate-screening/ ; engineering blog — eightfold.ai/engineering-blog/ai-powered-talent-matching...
- HireVue, assessment software — hirevue.com/platform/assessment-software
- PwC, assessment & selection process — pwc.co.uk/careers/early-careers/applying/assessment-selection-process.html
- Ladders 2012 (eye-tracking) via Forbes — forbes.com/sites/susanadams/2012/03/26/what-your-resume-is-up-against/
- Ladders 2018 update via HR Dive — hrdive.com/news/.../541582/ ; CNBC — cnbc.com/2018/12/06/ladders-ceo-marc-cenedella-3-ways...
- The Interview Guys, "The 6-second scan was a rejection" — blog.theinterviewguys.com/the-6-second-resume-scan...
- ISE Student Recruitment Survey 2024/25 via Staffing Industry — staffingindustry.com/news/global-daily-news/competition-for-uk-graduate-jobs-heats-up-in-2024 ; ise.org.uk
- Mergers & Inquisitions, low-GPA IB — mergersandinquisitions.com/low-gpa-investment-banking/
- CFAC/BYU, "recruiters spend seconds; networking gets the minutes" — cfac.byu.edu/...
- ResumeAdapter, ATS-by-company detection — resumeadapter.com/ats/workday/companies

§2 — Structure & layout

- Mergers & Inquisitions, IB resume guide — mergersandinquisitions.com/investment-banking/recruitment/resumes/
- Wall Street Prep, IB resume template — wallstreetprep.com/knowledge/investment-banking-resume-template/
- Preplounge, IB resume 2026 — preplounge.com/en/blog/finance/investment-banking/interview/resume
- Kyle Blockley (recruiter), "Common mistakes in CVs for banking" — linkedin.com/pulse/common-mistakes-cvs-banking-kyle-blockley
- Bright Network, IB CV guide/template — brightnetwork.co.uk/career-path-guides/investment-banking/
- r/FinancialCareers, "How many pages... (UK)" — reddit.com/r/FinancialCareers/comments/u19u5p ; "1 page or 2" — [/comments/sk03w0](https://reddit.com/r/FinancialCareers/comments/sk03w0)
- Adobe UK, CV length (generalist counterview) — adobe.com/uk/express/learn/blog/how-many-pages-should-a-cv-be

§3 — Bullet-point architecture

- KudosWall/Medium, STAR vs CAR vs XYZ — medium.com/kudoswall/how-to-write-powerful-resume-bullet-points...
- Wonsulting, the XYZ formula — wonsulting.com/job-search-hub/the-power-of-quantifiable-results...
- Career Principles (Kenji), stand-out IB resume — careerprinciples.com/resources/stand-out-investment-banking-resume
- UC Riverside, action verbs for business majors (PDF) — business.ucr.edu/.../Resume_Action_Verbs_for_Business_Majors.pdf
- Yale OCS, resume action verbs — ocs.yale.edu/resources/resume-action-verbs/
- InterviewPal, financial action verbs — interviewpal.com/action-verbs/financial-skills
- The Muse, quantifying without numbers — themuse.com/advice/how-to-quantify-your-resume-bullets-when-you-dont-work-with-numbers
- Jobscan, accomplishments without numbers — jobscan.co/blog/dont-need-numbers-accomplishments-resume/
- r/FinancialCareers, "I've reviewed thousands of resumes" — reddit.com/r/FinancialCareers/comments/8zrmc2/ ; "Finance resume" — [/comments/g4l0x6](https://reddit.com/r/FinancialCareers/comments/g4l0x6/)

§4 — Technical vocabulary (regulators & primary bodies bolded)

- **FCA Handbook COBS 3** (client categorisation) — handbook.fca.org.uk/handbook/COBS/3/ ; **Financial Crime Guide (FCG)** — handbook.fca.org.uk/handbook/fcg7 ; **financial sanctions** — fca.org.uk/firms/financial-crime/financial-sanctions ; **T+1 settlement** — fca.org.uk/markets/about-t1-settlement
- **ESMA**, MiFID II suitability guidelines — esma.europa.eu/press-news/esma-news/esma-publishes-final-guidelines-mifid-ii-suitability-requirements-0
- **EFAMA**, UCITS — efama.org/policy/eu-fund-regulation/ucits
- **The Investment Association**, fund structures (CTI PDF) — theia.org/sites/default/files/2020-07/CTI%20fund%20structures.pdf
- **CFA Institute**, distribution channels — rpc.cfainstitute.org/blogs/enterprising-investor/2020/responsible-innovation-in-distribution-three-channels-for-asset-managers
- **BNY**, custody/settlement — bny.com (custody solutions) ; **BlackRock**, Aladdin — blackrock.com/aladdin
- ComplyAdvantage, source of funds vs wealth — complyadvantage.com/insights/what-is-source-of-funds-source-wealth/
- Corporate Finance Institute, buy-side vs sell-side — corporatefinanceinstitute.com/resources/career/buy-side-vs-sell-side/
- DiligenceVault, RFP vs DDQ vs RFI — diligencevault.com/ddq-vs-rfp-vs-rfi-vs-15c-event-driven-diligence-asset-managers/

§5 — Insight days & thin experience

- r/FinancialCareers, "[UK] how to write about spring weeks" — reddit.com/r/FinancialCareers/comments/v6d9ov/ ; "how to improve my cv" — [/comments/x36ras](https://reddit.com/r/FinancialCareers/comments/x36ras/) ; customer service — [/comments/v8luva](https://reddit.com/r/FinancialCareers/comments/v8luva/) ; retail bank — [/comments/zuifiv](https://reddit.com/r/FinancialCareers/comments/zuifiv/)
- WSO, Non-Target Recruiting Guide Part I — wallstreetoasis.com/forum/investment-banking/non-target-recruiting-guide-part-i-resume-and-networking
- TARGETjobs, "What is a spring week/insight day" — targetjobs.co.uk/careers-advice/internships/what-spring-week-insight-day-or-insight-programme
- Calibre, spring-week CV guide (partial access) — calibreco.co.uk/blog/spring-week-cv-guide

- Bright Network, insight weeks / commitment signalling — brightnetwork.co.uk

§6 — Grades & non-target (live firm pages)

- UBS Graduate Talent Program — ubs.com/global/en/careers/early-careers/graduate-talent-program.html
- Barclays FAQ — search.jobs.barclays/faqs
- BlackRock EMEA students & graduates — careers.blackrock.com/students-and-graduates-emea
- Schroders graduate FAQ — schroders.com/en-gb/uk/institutional/about-us/careers/graduates/faqs/
- Fidelity International early careers — careers.fidelityinternational.com/early-careers-overview/
- M&G graduate opportunities — group.mandg.com/careers/routes-into-mandg/graduate-opportunities
- Pictet graduate programmes — pictet.com/uk/en/careers/graduate-programmes
- PwC removes 2:1 (press release, 14 Aug 2022) — pwc.co.uk/press-room/press-releases/corporate-news/pwc-removes-2-1-criteria...
- CFA UK, IMC — cfauk.org/learn/qualifications/investment-management-certificate
- 300hours, CFA exam dates & fees — 300hours.com/cfa-exam-dates

§7 — Interests

- r/FinancialCareers, "Started getting more interviews after including interests" — reddit.com/r/FinancialCareers/comments/ypyjyq ; "Do you include interests?" — [/comments/1796jjb](https://reddit.com/r/FinancialCareers/comments/1796jjb)
- Investin, CV hobbies dos & don'ts — investin.org/blogs/news/cv-hobbies-interests
- The Trackr, standout IB CV (partial access) — the-trackr.com/blog/writing-a-standout-investment-banking-cv-a-complete-guide/
- BeamJobs, 50 hobbies & interests — beamjobs.com/resume-help/hobbies-and-interests-for-resume
- CV Centre, best hobbies for a CV — cvcentre.co.uk/blog/cv-and-resume-writing-help/hobbies-for-cv
- Gentis (counter-view: skip hobbies) — gentis.com/en/blogs/
- WSO interests threads — wallstreetoasis.com/forum/resume/interests-line-on-resume (and related)

§8 — Cover letters, LinkedIn & networking

- Mergers & Inquisitions, networking guide — mergersandinquisitions.com/investment-banking/recruitment/networking/ ; cold email — [/how-to-cold-email-for-an-internship/](https://mergersandinquisitions.com/investment-banking/recruitment/networking/how-to-cold-email-for-an-internship/) ; LinkedIn profile — [/investment-banking-linkedin-profile/](https://mergersandinquisitions.com/investment-banking/recruitment/networking/linkedin-profile/)
- FE Training, cold email guide — fe.training/free-resources/investment-banking/the-ultimate-investment-banking-cold-email-guide/
- Preplounge, IB cover letter 2026 — preplounge.com/en/blog/finance/investment-banking/interview/cover-letter
- Intervyo, LinkedIn for finance recruiting — intervyo.co.uk/advice/linkedin-for-recruiting
- r/FinancialCareers, "What's the point of networking..." — [/comments/1bwqvhd](https://reddit.com/r/FinancialCareers/comments/1bwqvhd) ; "Networking and referrals" — [/comments/hhgkxx](https://reddit.com/r/FinancialCareers/comments/hhgkxx) ; "Non-target students" — [/comments/rvdmes](https://reddit.com/r/FinancialCareers/comments/rvdmes)

Appendix C — Where the evidence was thin or contradictory

READ THIS BEFORE OVER-TRUSTING ANY SINGLE CLAIM

Genuine contradictions (both sides shown in-text, not flattened):

- **Keyword scoring** — "myth" (Greenhouse: humans score) vs "real but misunderstood" (Workday match score). The blog sources are internally inconsistent; treat parsing specifics as informed consensus, not vendor fact. (*Section 1.3*)
- **Interests section** — read and valued (multiple practitioners) vs ignored ("we really don't care", corporate recruiter). (*Section 7.1*)
- **CV length** — one page (dominant, UK grads) vs two (experienced/public-sector exception). (*Section 2.2*)
- **Insight days** — include as a signalling credential vs omit thin ones. (*Section 5.1*)

Thin / secondary evidence, flagged as such:

- **Stage-by-stage funnel conversion percentages** (~15–20% pass screening, ~2–3% offer rates) are from careers blogs, not audited data. The 188:1 applications-per-vacancy figure is primary (ISE). Per-bank raw counts could not be verified — the primary eFinancialCareers article returned HTTP 405.
- **Which firm runs which ATS** — high confidence where a live careers URL exists (Barclays/Workday, Schroders/Taleo, Pictet/SuccessFactors, BlackRock/Workday+tal.net); medium/low for JPM and M&G.
- **"Salesforce/Dynamics are the standard AM CRMs"** — could not be sourced to an industry body; use only as tools you personally used. (Aladdin ≠ CRM is firmly sourced to BlackRock.)
- **Some operational terms** (static data, onboarding SLA, CLM) are vendor/industry-defined, not regulator-codified — safe to use, but describe by what you did rather than citing them as law. (*Section 4, marked [I].*)

Access limitations during research:

- **Reddit** hard-blocks the web crawler; threads were read via Redlib/reader proxies, so quotes are *near-verbatim* — canonical URLs are given so you can verify. **Wall Street Oasis** returned HTTP 403 to direct fetch (read via reader proxy).
- **Goldman Sachs** and **J.P. Morgan** canonical eligibility pages are JavaScript shells with no readable criteria; JPM's 2:1 was confirmed from live 2026 London job postings, not a single canonical page. Goldman's "no stated minimum, strong academics in practice" rests on eFinancialCareers reporting.
- **Amundi** has no dedicated UK graduate-eligibility page; its row is "none found," not "confirmed none."
- **HireVue's 2025 AI Explainability Statement** PDF would not extract; its AI claims rest on secondary analysis + platform pages.
- The **ISE 2025** report's exact figures on how prevalent UCAS/A-level filtering remains were not extractable (likely gated).

Where this guide makes a claim without a citation, it is my synthesis or judgement — treated as such, and separated from the sourced facts above.

Compiled for Janak Chohan, 2 August 2026. Built from the research of five parallel source-mining passes across Wall Street Oasis, Reddit (r/FinancialCareers), YouTube/creator content, LinkedIn recruiter posts, live firm application pages, ATS-vendor documentation and recruiter eye-tracking studies. Every substantive claim is cited inline and listed above. Where practitioners disagreed, both positions were shown. Nothing in the recommended rewrite fabricates or inflates experience — every line is built to survive a follow-up question in an interview.